

Blauw Films

Building Worlds

World Building Document

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Building Worlds

In The Beginning

So, you want to build a world?!

Building a brand spanking new world from scratch can be a daunting task. Where do you even begin? There is a simple answer to that question, which we will repeatedly come back to throughout this document: the answer is character.

As with all the stories the linchpin that your world revolves around is character. You are not building a world to play God. You are building a world to help you tell a story, and your story is all about your characters.

World building involves the creation of an immersive fictional universe that serves as the backdrop for the film's story. Effective world building enhances the viewer's experience and engagement with the story, making them believe in and care about the characters and events within the film. This document explores the art of world building and provides insights into the key elements and techniques involved, and how you might utilise them to start building a world of your own.

The Shoulder Of Orion

Why is World Building Important?

Distance:

By removing the audience from our world and placing them into a new world, you can examine topics that might otherwise be too close to home. You can look at societal issues at arms length and challenge the audience in ways that you may not be able to do otherwise.

Immersion:

A well-developed, detailed world pulls the audience into the story, making their experience richer and more enjoyable.

Cohesion:

A carefully constructed world provides a consistent and logical framework for the narrative, preventing plot holes and inconsistencies, whilst further immersing your audience.

Character Development:

An immersive, cohesive world adds depth to your characters. The world can influence character backgrounds, motivations, and conflicts, and just as importantly, if not more importantly, the characters influence the world they inhabit.

World building is a crucial aspect of filmmaking, especially in genres like science fiction and fantasy, but there are elements of world building in most, if not all fictional works. You could be building a Galaxy and every star and planet inside it, or you could be building a corrupt police department in downtown Boston with just Mark Wahlberg inside it: both are world building!

There are in essence four types of worlds you can build:

New Worlds:

Completely new worlds with little to no connection with the real world:
Middle Earth, Westeros.

Parallel Worlds:

A world different to ours, but exists alongside ours:
The Wizarding World of Harry Potter, The Chronicles of Narnia, Space Jam!

Alternative Worlds (alternative history):

Our world in all but name, where a different chain of events have lead to a very different world:
The Marvel Cinematic Universe, Inglourious Basterds, District 9.

Our World:

Just our world! You don't always need ray-guns, elves and Quidditch to build a world! If you are writing about a fictional cowboy, in a non fictional town, in the wild wild west, you are still building their world. (Although having said that, I would definitely buy a ticket to watch cowboys with ray-guns play elves at Quidditch!)

Once you understand the type of world you are going to build, there are two questions you need to ask yourself:

What is my genre?

We often do not give too much thought to what genre we are writing because we tend to instinctively know it. Obviously Star Wars is Sci-Fi, Lord of the Rings is fantasy, and Ironman is Superhero. But having a clear knowledge of what genre you are writing about allows you to lean on genre specific troupes that can often get you out of tight corners whilst writing. Having this clear knowledge also allows to you cross genres, both Star Wars and Lord of the Rings are war films, both are coming of age stories. Knowing this will give you a structural blueprint and the clarity you need to help shape your story and build your world.

Who is my target audience?

It seems obvious, but knowing the demographic you are writing for is crucial. It dictates the language, tone and content of your story as well as being how you market the thing. Whether you are writing for children or adults, liberal or conservatives, boys or girls, this can have a large effect on every aspect of your story, and therefore every aspect of your world. This should be measured carefully before laying the first brick.

Iceberg Right Ahead!

Sanderson:

(Here's a good moment to mention Brandon Sanderson (author of many works, including the Mistborn Trilogy and the Stormlight Archive). He gave a series of lectures at Brigham Young University on writing Science Fiction and Fantasy. He made these lectures available for free on Youtube and they are an invaluable resource for any writer, whether you work in prose or film, or in Sci-Fi Fantasy or not. These lectures colour much of next couple of sections and I would strongly advise all writers of any level of ability and experience to give them a watch.)

The Hollow Iceberg Theory:

"I always try to write on the principle of the iceberg. There is seven-eighths of it underwater for every part that shows. Anything you know, you can eliminate and it only strengthens your iceberg." — Ernest Hemingway

"Hemingway said that only the tip of the iceberg showed in fiction—your reader will see only what is above the water—but the knowledge that you have about your character that never makes it into the story acts as the bulk of the iceberg. And that is what gives your story weight and gravitas." — Jenna Blum

Hemingway is right, but he is also wrong! Sanderson accepts the importance of Hemingway's Iceberg Theory but points out that, yes, the audience can only see the tip of the iceberg and, yes, when they look into the water they need to have the impression of the full iceberg below, but that iceberg can be hollow.

You do not need to work out every single minute detail of your world. You need to work out what is important to the story and what is important for you to write the story. The audience need to feel the depth of your world but they will never see beyond the tip of the iceberg. Just do as much as you need for you to tell your story as effectively as possible.

We are not all J.R.R. Tolkien or George R.R. Martin. We can't all spend the better chunk of our lives developing an entire world, its complete history, and every language ever spoken in it. Of course if this is what interests you then by all means do it, but do not feel obliged to. You are building a world to tell a story, not to live in it.

Don't Panic!

The Eye of the Beholder:

Some artists do hyper detailed paintings with a million intricate strokes. Some paint a canvas a single colour and sell it for millions. Both are art. There is an audience for both. If you are feeling overwhelmed by the detail, then don't focus on the details. There's no one way to tell a story or build a world.

Fix it in Post!:

If you're in any way intimidated about world building, don't worry about it. Write your story and then come back to it and fill in the details later.

The Devil's in the Detail:

Start Simple. It's easy to get bogged down in the detail. Deliver your world building through the eyes of the characters. Ground your audience by grounding your characters in the world. Focus in on something clear that your character wants, and they must proactively interact with the world to get, and only include details of your world necessary to tell that journey and nothing more.

If you start with a scene that is set in Hogwarts, you have a hell of a lot of explaining to do to catch the audience up with the inner workings of your world, and this could potentially alienate the audience. Start with Uncle Vernon going to work and encountering Wizards on the streets. Don't start with the Intergalactic Federation, start with Princess Leia running away from Darth Vader to get a message to Obi Wan. Break your audience in gently or they might spook. Think about this as a learning curb for the audience, the less steep the curb, the easier it is for the audience to understand your world and therefore immerse themselves in it. Note that the younger the audience the lower the curb should be.

If you've successfully laid the simple character-driven ground work that allows the audience to suspend their disbelief and accept the characters exist in your world, then they will accept the more complicated details. Once you've established and grounded your world, characters and audience, you can then start hanging the bells and whistles on your world: showing the details, but do not feel the need to rush it. Do not overwhelm the audience with too much lore immediately. Allow them to gradually discover it as your protagonist progresses on their journey. Start simple.

Show Don't Tell:

It is important to avoid exposition, but if you are finding it hard to get the finer details of your world across to the audience, Apprentice Plots are a useful tool to break the audience in. See your world through the eyes of a newbie who is learning about the world in tandem with the audience, like Doctor Watson in the Sherlock Holmes Stories, Holmes can reel off exposition to the audience by reeling it off to Watson. Be cautious that this is somewhat of a cheat code and has been done to death. The easiest way of showing instead of telling is to make sure your characters actively interact with the world around them.

(Note: Peter Jackson's Fellowship of the Ring prologue and Star War's opening crawl is cheating! Try and avoid resorting to these stylised exposition dumps and only use them if strictly necessary to flesh out the history of your world!)

You're a Wizard, Harry!

Let's talk about magic! I know that not every story will contain magic, but the lessons you can learn from how to handle magic, and how to build magic systems in your world building are useful in learning how to handle setting, plot and character.

Hard and Soft Magic:

Firstly, let's talk about the different types of magic available to you. There is a wide spectrum of magic. Sanderson breaks this down into soft magic at one end of the spectrum, and hard magic at the other. Of course your magic can fall anywhere in between, but understanding the two extremes is important in creating a logical and believable magic system.

Hard Magic:

Hard magic adheres to strict, well-defined rules. It is more of a science. It's all about creating a system with clear cause-and-effect relationships, where characters and the audience understand the mechanics of spells, their abilities and limitations.

Soft Magic:

Soft magic is less well defined. The rules are more flexible, and characters and the audience might not fully understand how it works. To sum it up in a word, soft magic is about Wonder. Soft magic is often used in a symbolic and metaphorical manner.

Examples:

The world of *Harry Potter* largely consists of hard magic, well-defined spells with rules, allowing the characters and audience to learn about and understand the magical system. However, the most powerful magic force is love. Love is a thematic soft magic that imbues the stories with a sense of wonder.

In *Lord of the Rings*, magic is largely a soft force. It lacks rigid rules, leaving room for wonder. Although the audience believes that Gandalf may have hard magical abilities, these abilities are never explained, often happening in the background, keeping them in the realms of soft magic. However, some elements are made from harder magic, like the One Ring with its explicit rules: if you wear it you turn invisible, but at the cost of Sauron being able to see you and it corrupting your mind.

These stories both demonstrate perfect examples of the potential in balancing between soft and hard magic. Allowing your audience to both understand the magic, and therefore intellectually participating with it, whilst simultaneously not losing their sense of wonder.

Sanderson's Laws:

Brandon Sanderson came up with three laws to consider when developing magic systems in world building:

Sanderson's First Law:

"An author's ability to solve conflict with magic is directly proportional to how well the reader understands said magic. "

Magic isn't just a get-out-of-jail-free card. It is important your magic system has clear and consistent rules. It is important to earn the right to use your magic. It needs to be properly foreshadowed, with a clear set up and pay off. Your magic should have limitations and a

well-defined structure so the audience can follow how it works, helping you avoid any moments of deus ex machina.

But what if you're not writing about magic? These rules still apply. They can be conflated with the setting and the characters.

Just like with magic, the more your audience understands about your world, the better they can connect with it. If you're writing about a time or a place, make sure your readers know its rules and how it operates. With your characters make sure their arcs are properly set up and developed, make sure their motivations are well established and their subsequent actions are clear.

Sanderson's Second Law:

"Limitations > Powers."

It's not all about what magic can do; it's about what it can't do. Limitations are where the real magic happens! Restrictions and rules make the story more interesting. It's where the challenges and conflicts are. It's like two cowboys in a shootout, it's not the guns that adds the drama; it's the number of bullets they have.

The idea of limitation being greater or more important than the power can be used in developing your setting. If you write about a sun drenched world where everything runs on solar power, it's what happens when the clouds roll in and the sun disappears that you will find your drama.

When it comes to character, their flaws, vulnerabilities, and personal struggles make them more compelling. It's the limitations that make them real and relatable.

This can be broken down into flaws, limitations and cost. Flaws is what your character can not currently do; they will have to work and train to overcome these flaws. Limitations is what the character can not do; a permanent limitation that they have to learn to live and work with. Cost is what your character has to give up in order to get what they want. Harry Potter has to give up his life to defeat Voldemort. Peter Parker has to risk his normal life to become Spiderman.

Sanderson's Third Law:

"Expand what you already have before you add something new."

Before you go adding a bunch of new stuff to your magical system, explore what you've already got and expand on what's already there. This keeps things consistent and avoids making your magic system look like a jumbled mess. More is not strictly better. It is easier to get submerged in a deep well than it is in an inch deep ocean.

When it comes to characters, delve into their backgrounds, motivations, and relationships before throwing new characters into the mix. It makes the story richer and keeps everything consistent and engaging.

In world building, it's about making your setting more immersive. A well developed village is more interesting than a hundred under developed cities.

Sanderson' Zeroth Law:

Sanderson also has a fourth rule referred to as Sanderson' Zeroth Law:

He simply states, *"always air on the side of what is awesome!"*

The expression, 'the world is at your finger tips' doesn't do it justice. Every conceivable universe is at your finger tips! You can write anything, create anything, say anything! Don't hold back and just be awesome!

The Beginning of Wisdom

With this myriad of infinite possibilities stretched out before you, it can get a bit overwhelming, not just for you, but for the audience too. The simplest way to balance these possibilities within a world that feels consistent and believable is to constantly come back to the word 'Logic'.

There's two types of logic you need to think about:

Internal logic and external logic.

Internal Logic:

Think of internal logic as setting up the ground rules for your world. It's the framework that defines how everything functions, from the structure of your societies and the laws of nature, to how magic and technology works. The key is that these rules should make sense within the context of your world, and they should stay consistent unless there's a very good reason for change, but even this change should make logical sense within your world. Gravity can suddenly disappear but you still need to the audience to understand why.

If your world's rules change without rhyme or reason, the audience can become disoriented and lose the thread of the story. Consistency is key for keeping your audience immersed and satisfied. Immersion is about emotional engagement. When your world's internal logic is well established and understood, it can intensify the emotional impact of your story.

When your internal logic and rules are consistent and the audience understand these rules, they can predict how they might effect the story. They become active participants in your world. Predictability isn't necessarily a bad thing. Audiences can feel cheated if a story goes to far from their expectations.

If the murderer turns out to be a random character you have introduced in the third act, the audience will feel like they have wasted their time. When your audience knows how your world operates, they can anticipate what might happen next. This anticipation increases their connection with the characters and keeps them more immersed in the story.

(For longer series, it's beneficial to introduce slight gaps in your internal logic. Suppose you have a wizard who knows all magic, and later you need a new spell to resolve a plot point. If the wizard conveniently performs this new magic without explanation, the audience might feel shortchanged. By establishing that the wizard doesn't know everything, you allow room for character growth and new additions. While in a standalone story, you could backtrack in the edit and foreshadow the new magic, in a series, you're bound by the world you've already created and delivered to your audience.)

In your world, just like in reality, actions should have consequences. If your characters breaks the rules, there must be repercussions. The choices and decisions made by characters should lead to evolution. These outcomes, whether positive or negative, will impact character growth and progress the story.

If the audience know that certain actions will lead to certain outcomes it will increase the overall tension. If you established the laws and a character breaks them, they might go to jail. If you've established the necessity of oxygen and a character's space suit malfunctions, they won't be able to breath.

Every conflict in your story should be built on cause and effect, anchoring conflicts in the logic of your world. This ensures that conflicts are grounded in the logic of your world. As a result, when characters resolve conflicts, the outcomes feel earned and satisfying and the

audience will be able to follow and empathise with your characters' emotional arcs. This consistent logic keeps the tension raised and the audience engaged. Consistency helps facilitate the suspension of disbelief; a vital aspect of storytelling. When your world's internal logic remains steady, it allows readers or viewers to immerse themselves more deeply in the narrative without constantly questioning its plausibility. Consistency also adds to the sense of realism. Even if your rules are different from the rules of our reality, that constant consistency of your internal logic will help ground the audience. Inconsistent world building can lead to plot holes that can confuse or frustrate you and your audience. Consistency prevents such issues, helping maintain the structure of your narrative.

External Logic:

External logic is the logic of our reality. Walls are solid, fires burn and cows go moo!

Consider how easy it is for your audience to step into your world. If your world is too convoluted or bizarre, you might put your audience off straight away. That's not to say you should not be bizarre, but take into account the learning curve of your audience and break them in gently.

If everyone in your world walks backwards and never seem to bump into anything, even if you have worked hard to establish the cultural reasons for them walking backwards, the audience will not be able to accept the lack of bumping into things! If however the wealthy walk backwards and they use servants to guide them, then the internal and external logic work in tandem and the audience will accept this unusual quirk of your world. The key is to strike that balance between uniqueness and familiarity. You want to captivate your audience and not alienate them.

External logic often involves using familiar elements, whether that is gravity, mothers giving birth or cows going moo! You can draw inspiration from real-world cultures, history, and landscapes to create unique and believable fictional worlds. It can help the audience feel enough recognition that they do not feel immediately lost.

You can also use genre troupes to help maintain this sense of familiarity, as well as being inspired by other works. Zombies have entered into the realms of external logic. Audiences recognise Zombies, meaning you have to do less work to establish and explain them. If you use enough external logic, and are aware of that external logic, then it also gives you the opportunity to surprise the audience. As long as it makes sense in your internal logic, you can use their preexisting expectations to subvert their expectations and give the story impact.

Logic, whether internal or external, is your anchor and compass, guiding you and your audience through your world, making it believable and relatable. Consistency is the cornerstone of logic in world building. It brings believability, engagement, and depth to your creation, building a reliable framework that both you and your audience can rely on. It ensures that your story remains coherent and compelling, allowing the audience to fully immerse themselves in your world.

A Brave New World

Okay, now it's time for the fun part! What are the various elements that go into building a world?

You can break these elements into two main categories:

The **Physical Setting** and the **Cultural Setting** (although several of these cross over as culturally significant physical settings ie... cities, farms and magic).

(Remember to not feel intimidated by these lists. You do not need to include every element. The only elements you need to include are those that your characters interact with and only to the level of detail necessary to tell your story.)

Physical Setting:

Rules of physics:

What are the fundamental laws that make up the foundations your world's mechanics?

- These rules govern the behaviour of natural laws, such as how objects move and energy flows, as well as how technology functions.
- These rules are what ensure that your world maintains a coherent internal logic.

In a world where people can manipulate gravity at will, cities may be built in the sky or on the sides of cliffs.

Weather, climate, and seasons:

Is your world hot, cold or something in between?

- These elements don't just determine if your characters need to wear sunscreen or not; they mould the very landscapes and ecosystems of your world.
- They influence everything from agriculture to attire, as well as setting the tone for each scene in your story.

In a world where unending storms ravage the land, and the sun only breaks through the perpetual clouds for a few minutes each year. This unrelenting climate can shape your landscapes with windswept deserts and subterranean cities, and give you characters a clear obstacle to overcome in pursuit of their goals.

Maps:

Do you understand the layout of your world?

- Maps offer a visual guide to your world's layout, ensuring that the audience can navigate your creation with clarity.
- Even if not shared with the audience, maps can still be useful to create for your own sense of your world's time and geography whilst writing.
- A map can also be useful MacGuffin (a plot device that pushes the story forward and

gets characters moving) helping set clear goals, and driving the plot forward.

When a farmhand finds an ancient map marked with an X he steals his boss's horse and goes in search of whatever treasures lie in wait.

Mountains, Valleys, Plains and Deserts:

What is the topography of your world?

- More than just a scenic backdrop, mountains, valleys, plains and deserts shape the very identity of your world.
- They form natural barriers, dictate climate patterns, and influence the availability of resources.
- These landscapes can offer clear, tangible goals and obstacles to your characters.

Climbing a mountain is a perfect example of story structure. A character has a clear goal: to get to the top, obstacles: the mountain, its glaciers and ravines, and a resolution: to get back down. A diagram of story structure looks like a mountain for a reason!

Tectonic activity:

What sculpted your continents, mountains, and oceans?

- Tectonic activity is the force shaping your landscapes and ecosystems.
- Volcanoes are visually appealing and their natural volatility can be thematically interesting.

In a world where tectonic activity is so intense that the continents move aggressively, causing landmasses to collide and drift apart in a matter of years. This geological chaos could create a nomadic lifestyle where cities are built on colossal mobile platforms, and conflict arises through the uncontrolled movement of the cities.

Oceans, seas, lakes, and rivers:

What is the lifeblood of your world?

- Oceans, seas, lakes, and rivers aren't just bodies of water; they shape the very essence of geography, climate, and ecosystems.
- They're the basis of trade routes, cultural influences, and resource distribution.
- They serve as natural barriers, focal points for conflict, and are vital avenues of transportation.
- Bodies of water are where you would find most cities, towns and villages.

In a world where there is nothing but ocean and the natural resources are all collected by one giant wave constantly circumnavigating the planet. Civilisations would have to build cities that follow behind the wave, with characters risking their lives to mine the stormy depths of the tsunami.

Flora:

What colours your landscape?

- Plant life influences the diet, medicine, and materials available to your characters, having a large impact on daily life.
- The location and variety of different plant species can effect different cultures, belief systems, and traditions.

In a land where enormous, carnivorous plants dominate the landscape, humans might have to build cities high above them, or deep below them, but if these dangerous plants have a flower that contains the only medicine that can save the Queen's life, the characters would have to venture from the safety of their cities to save their Queen.

Fauna:

What non-sapiens share your world?

- Incorporating diverse fauna adds greatly to the complexity of your world.
- Whether a mighty dragon or a humble cow, they're not just part of the background; they can impact agriculture, transportation, and the mythologies of your world.
- These creatures can be key players in the ecosystem of your world.
- They can be predators and pray.
- Diverse fauna will not only enrich your world, but present a variety of potential

challenges and opportunities to your characters.

In a world where enormous, flying birds fill the skies, cities are built on their backs, and entire societies are centred around their migrations and behaviours.

Natural Resources:

What are the foundations of opportunity and wealth in your world?

- Natural resources determine the availability of essential materials and energy, affecting technological advancements, trade networks, and societal structures.
- Settlements will be built up near resource rich areas, such as mines, forests, and water sources.

In a world where there are only two mines containing the only metal that can be used to make the space suits needed to survive, and one of those mines begins to run out of its supplies, the opposing forces will do anything to maintain control of the one remaining mine.

Cosmology:

What effect do stars have on your world and story?

- Cosmology can shape the beliefs, rituals, calendars, and potentially the supernatural elements of your world.
- They can also act as maps and compasses for your characters to navigate the world.

In a world where stars are sentient beings, with different societies worshipping different stars, when one star is destroyed by another in battle, the faction worshipping the defeated

star have to reevaluate the very fundamentals of their way of life, or avenge their God.

Cultural Setting:

Historic events:

How did we get here?

- These aren't just past events; they're the foundation of culture and politics.
- Historic events provide context to your characters' motivations and the conflicts that help shape your narrative.
- They are the foundations of cultural identities, shaping the very fabric of your societies.
In a kingdom where peace reigns after a humble blacksmith defeats a dragon, blacksmiths are now revered and stand in high office ruling over the people.

Calendars:

How is time measured in your world?

- Calendars can highlight the passage of time and seasons.
- They can also dictate cultural practices such as festivals.

In a world where seasons last for decades, calendars revolve around the blooming of a rare poisonous flower. When the flower blooms there is a grand festival where it is eaten by the elders, enabling them to pass to the next life free from sin. The blooming of the flower dictates the passing of power to the next generation.

Myths and legends:

What additional stories colour the history of your world?

- Like with history, myths and legends lay the foundation for belief systems, rituals, and your world's lore.
- They can help shape the motivations of your characters.

In a land surrounded by a dark forest it is said that children who venture into the forest will meet a grisly fate. It takes three brave children to embark on a journey to instead find a land of happy, forever-young children living in peace beyond the trees.

Languages:

How do people communicate in your world?

- Languages shape culture, further understanding, and build barriers between different characters and cultures.
- When creating your languages, character names, and place names, think about the root language. Whether drawing from Gaelic, Latin, or other roots, maintaining consistent patterns and alphabets lends authenticity to your world.
- Place names are normally given for a good reason; whether named after the person who discovered the place, the person who founded the city, a nearby river, or the indigenous wildlife that inhabits a particular area, in real life place names tend to have a logical

etymology.

In a world without words where people communicate only in dance, a girl from the cha cha district must teach her star crossed lover from the paso doble district how to dance the cha cha in order for him to ask her fathers permission to marry her!

Borders:

Where can't you go in your world and why?

- Borders are the boundaries that define cultural and geographic divisions.
- They not only physically divide different territories but impact geopolitics relations such as diplomacy and trade, shaping the map, alliances and conflicts of your world.

In a world where borders are formed by the roots of huge, ancient trees, the steady peace of the different nations come under threat as the roots begin to wither and die.

Cities, towns, and villages:

Where do people live in your world?

- Cities, towns, and villages are the centre of human (or alien) existence.
- They are the heart of culture, commerce, and community.
- They define societal structures, livelihoods, and lifestyles.
- As well as being the backdrop for your story, they can themselves be characters of your world, each with their own back stories and goals.
- The location of them can be determined for reasons of access and security. For example, high up cliffs away from predators, potential enemies, or underground, away from storms.
- They are usually always by a body of water or an area rich in natural resources.
- These settlements can range from a state's capital city down to the lowliest hamlet.

The inhabitants of a city on a cloud live a happy prosperous existence, high above the chaos of the cities below, but when one day the cloud breaks and it begins to rain, the wealthy inhabitants of the cloud city need to find their new place in society in the hubbub of the cities on the ground.

Agriculture:

Where are crops grown in your world?

- Agriculture is the crucial foundation of food production, trade, and societal structures.
- Farming can affect the cultures and daily routines of your characters.
- Farms can dictate the workings of the economy as well as the types of flora and fauna in an area.

In a world where crops only grow in a certain valley, the inhabitants dig the valley deeper and deeper, until one day they find the cause of the fertile land when they wake monster sleeping below.

Food:

What do people eat in your world and why?

- Food reflects traditions, cultural values, and the rhythms of daily life.
- You can tell a lot about a character from what, where and how they eat.
- Different foods can be an indication of wealth, religious views, and morality.

In a land where everyone is vegan, the world needs to make a tough decision when scientists discover that plants are more sentient than animals!

Religions:

What do people in your world believe in?

- Religions have an enormous influence over values and worldviews.
- Religions are not just facets of your world; they can be driving forces behind moral dilemmas, conflicts, and ethical decisions, acting as a spiritual compass, potentially guiding everyone of your characters' decisions.

Three religions fight tooth and nail for control of a planet that they all claim be their spiritual home.

Governments, Politics, Kings and Queens:

Who rules your world?

- Governments, Politicians, Kings and Queens are the governors of political structures and laws.
- They control the distribution of power and wealth within your world.
- They shape societal organisation, have power to begin and end wars, and control the allocation of crucial resources.

In a world where the leader is chosen through feats of strength and violence, war is perpetual, until an elderly lady out wits her opponent and becomes President, showing there is more to leadership than brute force.

Economics and Currency:

How does money work in your world?

- What are the systems of trade?
- How are resources and wealth distributed?
- Economics forms the foundation of livelihoods, social hierarchies, and financial dynamics in your world.
- It's the invisible, ever present force that shapes the 'class' of your characters and how they earn a living.

In a land where currency is based on the trade of sea shells, the wealthiest are those who control the coast lines. The most valuable shells lie on the bed of ocean so the strongest swimmers, who can hold their breath the longest, are the wealthiest and most power in society.

Employment:

What do your characters do for a living?

- This is how individuals earn their livelihoods, contribute to society, and navigate their roles within your world.
- Employment shapes the economic structures, social hierarchies, and daily routines of your world's population.

In a society at war where nearly all work is organised around the the building of weapons, society crumbles when the long fought for peace is finally achieved.

Trading:

How are different resources spread in your world?

- Trading is the marketplace of your world, where goods, resources, and knowledge are exchanged.
- Trading influences economies, and potential relationships between different societies in your world.

In a world where trade relies on the buying, selling and enslavement of robot workers, the world is turned upside down when people begin to realise the robots are sentient beings.

Law and order:

What are the laws and what happens if you break them?

- These rules ensure justice and security within your world.
- They define how conflicts are resolved, rights are protected, and punishments are delivered.

In a land where legal disputes are settled through trial by combat, the strongest can do as they like, where as the weak must follow the laws.

Education:

How do your characters know what they know, or how will they learn what they need to know?

- Education is key to the spreading of knowledge, skills, and cultural values.
- It can define the level of expertise, societal advancements, and the worldview of your characters and cultures.
- The distribution of educational resources can determine whether your world is a world of fairness or injustice.

- Education can be crucial to the development of your characters as they progress and grow.

In a world where only the poorest go to school, and the wealthy spend their days drinking and socialising, it does not take long for the educated poor to outwit and topple those who held the wealth and power.

Social hierarchy:

Where do your characters stand socially?

- The social hierarchy dictates the structure of power, privilege, and social roles within your world.
- It can shape class divisions, relationships, and the levels of opportunity, defining the social landscape your characters must navigate.

In a culture where social status is determined by the size of one's feet, a lowly shoemaker risks his business and freedom by starting a black market for oversized shoes!

Fashion:

What do your characters wear and why?

- Fashion influences individual identity, societal values, and the aesthetics of your characters and cultures.
- Clothing can say a lot about the climate and the economy of your world,.
- It can also speak to the religious beliefs, occupations, social standing, and the general daily lives of your characters.

In a world where clothing is alive, organically grown rather than sewn, people must water and care for their garments. This leads to social inequality when the rich develop the best fertilising products and maintain control over the fields and water sources.

Social taboos:

What shouldn't your characters do?

- Social taboos can shape cultural norms.
- These unwritten rules can help drive your narrative, adding societal tensions and conflicts, and moral dilemmas for your characters.

In a society where it is morally and legally wrong to wear colourful clothes, a young fashion designer creates a secret night club where people can dress as brightly as they want.

Military traditions and Warfare:

Who in your world is fighting and why?

- Military traditions and warfare can shape much of the historic and present landscape of a world.
- Cultural and geographical borders are often drawn blood.
- External and internal conflicts are the main driving forces to create drama in the lives of your characters and your plots. War, in particular is the epitome of conflict, and can serve

as fertile ground to create this drama.

In a world where warfare is a game, nations play at war with armies engaging in choreographed battles, until one day someone switches the blank ammunition to live ammunition.

Technology:

What level of technology does your world have and how is it used?

- Technology is the engine that powers industry, communication, and large elements of daily life.
- It is what drives war, architecture, healthcare and space travel.
- Whether a plough, the printing press or ships capable of intergalactic space travel,

technology has a profound effect on the progress of society and the lives we lead. In a world mired by depression, an inventor creates a technology that psychologists can use to explore and perhaps change their patients' memories.

And finally (of course!)...

Magic:

Is there magic in your world (and if not, why not)?!

- Magic has the power to conjure belief systems and power structures.
- It can give your characters wondrous abilities.
- It can add a dimension to your world that transcends reality, offering your audience an escape into a nearly unrecognisable world.
- When well established and foreshadowed, it can also be a useful narrative tool, helping solve more complexed plot points.

In a world where magical powers are fuelled by dreams, a young wizard inadvertently opens the dream realm, and peoples' dreams begin to seep into reality.

There are a multitude of potential settings that can be used to build your world's landscapes and cultures. Whether it's a crowded cyber-punk metropolis, a sleepy rural village, or a post-apocalyptic wasteland, each setting breathes life into your world, shaping your characters' goals, obstacles and very existence in thematically diverse and interesting ways.

At The End Of All Things

The essence of building a world, as reiterated time and again, is character. A rich, immersive world sets the stage, but it is the characters, with their stories, desires, and motivations, who breathe life into your world.

The spectrum of world building is vast, ranging from entirely unfamiliar realms like Middle Earth to the streets of our own world. Regardless of the type of world you're constructing, its foundation is character, your story's genre and your target audience. Knowing this will give you the clarity to ensure you build with purpose.

It's clear that the tip of the iceberg, or the surface level of your world, needs depth beneath. But this depth doesn't need to be exhaustive; it merely needs to be convincing. The Hollow Iceberg Theory teaches us that while thoroughness is commendable, it's not always necessary. The story should drive world development, not the other way around.

The route you choose to build your world, whether it's a detail-rich canvas or a minimalist masterpiece, remains a subjective art form. Start simple, introduce your audience to your world's intricacies gradually, ensuring they remain engaged and not overwhelmed. In the realms of magic, character, plot and setting, Sanderson's Laws underline the importance of well defined systems, emphasising limitations, consistency, and depth over breadth. But above all, Sanderson's Zeroth Law reminds us to prioritise what's truly spectacular. World building, at its heart, is about breaking boundaries and being audacious.

While the process of world building can seem like a colossus task, remember that its purpose is to facilitate your story, primarily driven by character. Dive deep into the resources available, absorb the wisdom of those who've tread this path before, but at the end of the day, let your unique voice shine through. After all, every conceivable universe is at your fingertips, waiting to be brought to life.

So, in the world of world building, be logical, be bold, be awesome, but above all... just write!

The biggest barrier to building a world is by not beginning...